

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	FULL MOON	NEW MOON
2020	February 9	February 23
2021	February 27	February 11
2022	February 16	February 1
2023	February 5	February 20
2024	February 24	February 9
2025	February 12	February 28
2026	February 1	February 17
2027	February 20	February 6

PLANETS

2020: February 10 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -0.3.

2022: February 16 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.2.

2026: February 19 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -0.4.

2027: February 3 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -0.3.

ECLIPSES

2026: February 17 An annular eclipse of the Sun is visible from southern South America, southern Africa, the south Pacific and Indian oceans, and Antarctica.

2027: February 6 An annular eclipse of the Sun is visible from Argentina, Chile, the Atlantic Ocean, and West Africa, with a partial eclipse visible across much of South America and Africa.

FEBRUARY

Castor and Pollux, the brightest stars in the northern zodiacal constellation of Gemini, lie close to the celestial meridian (the imaginary north-south line in the sky) on February evenings, as does Procyon in Canis Minor, which adjoins Gemini to the south. In the Southern Hemisphere, Carina, Puppis, and Vela—the three constellations that once formed the large ancient Greek constellation Argo Navis, ship of the Argonauts—are high in the sky.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

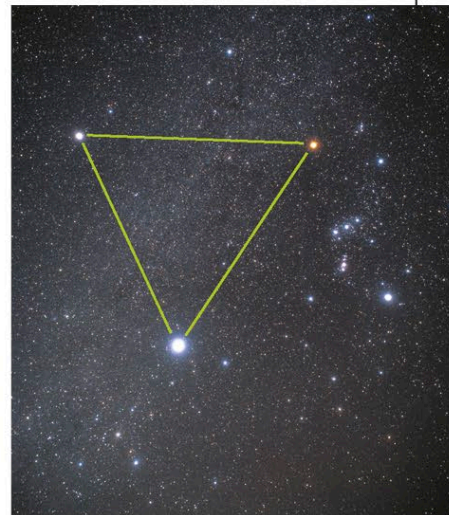
Gemini is almost overhead as seen from mid-northern latitudes in February, with the faintest of the zodiacal constellations, Cancer, close by but slightly lower in the sky. South of Gemini, the sparkling Winter Triangle formed by Sirius (in Canis Major), Betelgeuse (in Orion), and Procyon (in Canis Minor) remains prominent. Taurus, the Bull, backs away from Orion toward the western horizon, with Auriga and Perseus higher above it. Close to the northwest horizon is the W-shaped Cassiopeia. Leo, the Lion, is moving into the eastern sky, with the familiar figure of the Big Dipper above it in the northeast.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M35, a large open star cluster at the feet of Gemini, is easily seen through binoculars. The Beehive Cluster (see p.290)—also known as M44 or Praesepe—lies nearby in Cancer. Through binoculars, the Beehive is visible as a scattering of

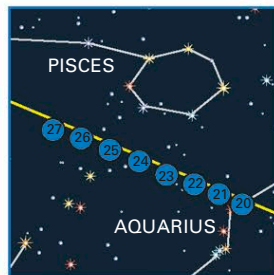
stars three times wider than a full moon; under ideal conditions, it can be glimpsed by the naked eye as a hazy patch—it was known to the ancient Greeks.

The Milky Way runs through Monoceros, an often-overlooked constellation framed by the Winter Triangle, which contains several open star clusters. One of the most notable of these clusters, NGC 2244, is visible through binoculars. It is located at the heart of the elusive Rosette Nebula, which is seen well only in photographs.



THE WINTER TRIANGLE
Brilliant Sirius (bottom) forms a prominent triangle in the northern winter sky with Procyon (top left) and Betelgeuse (top right).

NEPTUNE



MIDNIGHT

3 A.M.

6 A.M.

9 A.M.

NOON

